# Gender, Religion and Caste

## The big idea

Every society has differences: between women and men, among religions, among castes. Democracy does not try to erase these differences; it asks how they should be **expressed in politics**. Sometimes political expression of social differences helps disadvantaged groups win justice; sometimes it divides people and leads to violence. This chapter looks at three such differences: **gender, religion and caste**.

## Gender and politics

Gender division is a form of hierarchical social division seen everywhere, but it is rarely recognised in the study of politics. It is often understood as natural and unchangeable. However, it is based not on biology but on **social expectations and stereotypes**.

**SEXUAL DIVISION OF LABOUR**

A system in which **all work inside the home is either done by the women of the family, or organised by them through domestic helpers**. Boys and girls are brought up to believe that the main responsibility of women is housework and bringing up children. Women do work outside (fetching water, collecting fuel, working in fields) but their work is often **not valued** and does not get recognition. An average woman works **one hour more** than an average man every day (Time Use Survey), yet much of her work is unpaid. Men are willing to do the same work outside the home if paid (most tailors and cooks in hotels are men).

As a result, women's role in public life, especially politics, has been minimal in most societies. Women's political agitations demanded equal rights for women: voting rights, enhancement of political and legal status, and improvement of educational and career opportunities. Radical women's movements aimed at equality in personal and family life as well; these movements are called **feminist movements**.

**FEMINIST**

A woman or a man who **believes in equal rights and opportunities for women and men**.

In **Scandinavian countries** such as **Sweden, Norway and Finland**, the participation of women in public life is very high.

**Women's disadvantage in India**: India is a **patriarchal** society (literally, rule by father; a system that values men more and gives them power over women).

- **Literacy**: literacy rate among women is only **65.46%** compared with **82.14%** among men (Census 2011). A smaller proportion of girl students go for higher studies; parents prefer to spend resources on boys' education.
- **Jobs and wages**: the proportion of women among highly paid and valued jobs is still very small. The **Equal Remuneration Act, 1976** provides that equal wages should be paid for equal work. However, in almost all areas of work, from sports and cinema to factories and fields, women are paid less than men, even when both do exactly the same work.
- **Son preference**: in many parts of India, parents prefer sons and find ways to have the girl child aborted (sex-selective abortion). This has led to a decline in the **child sex ratio** (number of girl children per thousand boys) in the country to merely **919** (Census 2011); in some states it is below 850 or even 800.
- **Violence and safety**: there are reports of harassment, exploitation and violence against women. Urban areas have become particularly unsafe for women; even at home, women face beatings and domestic violence.

**Women's political representation.** In India, the proportion of women in legislatures has been very low. For example, the percentage of elected women members in the **Lok Sabha** touched **14.36 per cent** of its total strength for the first time in **2019**. Their share in state assemblies is less than 5 per cent. In this respect, India is among the bottom group of nations in the world. One way to solve this problem is to make it legally binding to have a fair proportion of women in elected bodies. This is what the **Panchayati Raj** has done: **one-third of seats in local government bodies** are reserved for women. There are now more than **10 lakh** elected women representatives in rural and urban local bodies. Women's organisations and activists long demanded a similar reservation of at least one-third of seats in Lok Sabha and State Assemblies for women; such a law, the **Constitution (106th Amendment) Act / Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam**, was passed in **2023** (to come into effect after the next delimitation).

**GENDER AS A POLITICAL ISSUE WORKS**

Gender division is one example where some form of social division needs to be expressed in politics. Disadvantaged groups benefit when social divisions become a political issue. Political expression of gender issues helped improve women's role in public life.

## Religion, communalism and politics

Gandhiji used to say that **religion can never be separated from politics**. By religion, he meant not any particular religion like Hinduism or Islam but the **moral values that inform all religions**. He believed politics must be guided by ethics drawn from religion.

Human rights groups argue that most victims of communal riots in India are people from **religious minorities**, and demand special steps to protect them. The women's movement argues that **family laws** of all religions discriminate against women, so government should change them to make them more equitable.

These instances involve a relationship between religion and politics, but they are not wrong: people should be able to express their needs, interests and demands in politics as members of a religious community, and the state should ensure that no religion is discriminated against.

### COMMUNALISM

The problem begins when **religion is seen as the basis of the nation**, when beliefs of one religion are presented as superior to those of other religions, when demands of one religious group are formed in opposition to another, and when **state power is used to establish domination of one religious group** over the rest. This manner of using religion in politics is **communal politics**. It is based on the idea that religion is the principal basis of social community, that followers of a particular religion must belong to one community, and that their fundamental interests are the same and different from (or opposed to) those of followers of other religions.

**Forms of communalism in politics:**

1. **In everyday beliefs**: religious prejudices, stereotypes of religious communities and belief in the superiority of one's religion over others.
2. **Desire for political dominance**: a communal mind often leads to a quest for political dominance of one's own religious community. For those belonging to the majority community, this takes the form of **majoritarian dominance**; for those of the minority community, it can take the form of a desire to form a **separate political unit**.
3. **Political mobilisation on religious lines**: using sacred symbols, religious leaders, emotional appeal and plain fear to bring followers of one religion together in politics. In electoral politics, this involves special appeal to the interests or emotions of voters of one religion in preference to others.
4. **Communal violence, riots and massacres**: India and Pakistan suffered some of the worst communal riots at the time of **Partition**. The post-independence period has also seen large-scale communal violence.

**SECULAR STATE**

Communalism was and continues to be one of the major challenges to democracy in our country. The makers of our Constitution chose the model of a **secular state**:

- There is **no official religion** for the Indian state. Unlike Buddhism in Sri Lanka, Islam in Pakistan and Christianity in England, our Constitution does not give a special status to any religion.
- The Constitution provides to all individuals and communities **freedom to profess, practise and propagate any religion**, or not to follow any.
- The Constitution **prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion**.
- At the same time, the Constitution **allows the state to intervene in the matters of religion** in order to ensure equality within religious communities. For example, it **bans untouchability**.

Secularism is not just an ideology of some parties or persons; it is one of the **foundations of our country**. Communalism must be combated in everyday life, and religion-based mobilisation must be countered in politics.

## Caste and politics

**Caste inequalities.** Gender and religious divisions exist all over the world, but **caste division is special to India**. Caste system was based on **exclusion of and discrimination against the 'outcaste'** groups, subjected to inhuman practices of untouchability. Hereditary occupational division was sanctioned by rituals. Members of the same caste group were supposed to form a social community that practised the same or similar occupation, married within the caste group and did not eat with members of other caste groups.

Political leaders and social reformers like **Jotiba Phule, Gandhiji, B.R. Ambedkar and Periyar Ramaswami Naicker** advocated and worked to establish a society in which caste inequalities are absent. Partly due to their efforts and partly due to socio-economic changes (**urbanisation, growth of literacy and education,**

**occupational mobility, and weakening of the position of landlords in villages**), caste hierarchy is breaking down. The Constitution prohibited any caste-based discrimination and laid foundations for policies to reverse injustices.

But caste has not disappeared: most people still marry within their own caste; untouchability persists despite constitutional prohibition; and effects of centuries of advantages and disadvantages continue: the caste groups that had access to education under the old system have done very well in acquiring modern education too. There is a large presence of "upper caste" among the urban middle classes, and caste continues to be closely linked to economic status.

**CASTE IN POLITICS**

- When parties choose candidates in elections, they keep in mind the **caste composition of the electorate** and nominate candidates from different castes so as to muster necessary support to win elections.
- Political parties and candidates make **appeals to caste sentiment** to muster support. Some parties are known to favour some castes.
- **Universal adult franchise** and the principle of **one-person-one-vote** compelled political leaders to gear up to mobilise and secure political support. It also brought new consciousness among people of castes that were hitherto treated as inferior and low.

**But elections are not only about caste:**

- **No parliamentary constituency in the country has a clear majority of one single caste.** So every candidate and party needs to win the confidence of more than one caste and community.
- **No party wins the votes of all the voters of a caste** or community. When people say a caste is a "vote bank" of a party, it usually means a large proportion of voters from that caste vote for that party.
- Many political parties may put up candidates from the same caste. Some voters have more than one candidate from their caste, while many voters have

no candidate from their caste.

- The ruling party and the sitting MP or MLA frequently **lose elections** in our country. That could not have happened if all castes and communities were frozen in their political preferences.
- Voters have strong attachments to political parties, often stronger than to their caste or community. People within the same caste or community have different interests depending on their economic condition. Rich and poor or men and women from the same caste often vote very differently. People's assessment of the government's performance and the popularity rating of leaders matter and are often decisive.

#### POLITICS IN CASTE

Politics too influences the caste system and caste identities by bringing them into the political arena. So it is not politics that gets caste-ridden; it is the **caste that gets politicised**:

- Each caste group tries to become bigger by **incorporating within it neighbouring castes or sub-castes** which were earlier excluded from it.
- Various caste groups are required to enter into **coalitions** with other castes or communities and thus enter into dialogue and negotiation.
- **New kinds of caste groups** have come up in the political arena, like **'backward' and 'forward'** caste groups.

Caste in politics has positive aspects: in some situations, expression of caste differences in politics gives many disadvantaged communities the space to demand their share of power; **Dalits and OBCs** have gained better access to decision-making. But exclusive attention to caste can produce negative results: it can divert attention from pressing issues like poverty, development and corruption, and in some cases leads to tensions, conflict and even violence.

#### "SECULAR MEANS ANTI-RELIGION"

A secular state is **not** against religion. It has no official religion, gives everyone religious freedom, prohibits discrimination, and may intervene to

ensure equality (e.g., banning untouchability).

**BOARD FAVOURITES**

"What is the sexual division of labour?", "Explain the status of women in India" (literacy, jobs, sex ratio, representation), "Forms of communalism in politics" (5 marks), "Features of the secular state in India" (3 marks), "Caste alone cannot determine election results: explain", "Role of caste in politics and politics in caste".

## Quick recap

- Gender division is social, not biological; sexual division of labour undervalues women's work.
- Women's literacy 65.46% vs men 82.14%; child sex ratio 919; Equal Remuneration Act 1976; women in Lok Sabha 14.36% (2019).
- One-third local body seats reserved for women; 2023 law for one-third seats in Lok Sabha and assemblies.
- Communalism: religion as basis of the nation; four forms from everyday beliefs to violence.
- India is a secular state: no official religion, freedom of religion, no discrimination, state may intervene for equality.
- Caste in politics (candidate selection, appeals, mobilisation) and politics in caste (bigger groups, coalitions, new categories).

## Practice questions

1. A system in which all work inside the home is done or organised by women is called
   (a) patriarchy (b) sexual division of labour (c) feminism (d) communalism
2. The Equal Remuneration Act was passed in
   (a) 1956 (b) 1976 (c) 1992 (d) 2005
3. Which of these is NOT a feature of India as a secular state?
   (a) No official religion (b) Freedom to profess, practise and propagate any religion (c) Prohibition of discrimination on grounds of religion (d) Special status to the religion of the majority
4. Communal politics is based on the idea that
   (a) religion should be kept out of all politics (b) all religions are equal (c) religion is the principal basis of social community (d) the state must ban religion
5. Which of these shows that caste alone does not determine election outcomes?
   (a) No parliamentary constituency has a clear majority of one caste (b) Parties consider caste while choosing candidates (c) Leaders appeal to caste sentiment (d) Universal adult franchise led to caste mobilisation
6. Scandinavian countries such as Sweden, Norway and Finland are known for
   (a) the lowest literacy among women (b) a communal form of politics (c) the caste system (d) very high participation of women in public life
7. The emergence of 'backward' and 'forward' caste groups in politics is an example of
   (a) caste in politics (b) communalism (c) majoritarianism (d) politics in caste (caste getting politicised)
8. Mention any three features of India as a secular state.
9. Describe the various forms that communalism can take in politics.

Answers: 1. b 2. b 3. d 4. c 5. a 6. d 7. d 8. see notes 9. see notes